

That Holo feeling...

I'M NOT TOO MUCH OF A PHONE GUY. Don't get me wrong, I love having a current generation flagship phone, but they don't excite me as much as they used to. I've just ordered an S10+ that should arrive in a week, and I'm pretty sure that when I open the box I won't be one-tenth as excited as I was when I bought the (then spanking new) Sony Ericsson K750i – wading through the infamous Mumbai floods of 2005 for 10 hours bricked my old phone. Like most of the others in Team Digit, I too am far more excited by CES, and SpaceX and ISRO launches than I am with Mobile World Congress, or pretty much anything to do with phones.

This is why, although MWC 2019 was overflowing with crazy cameras and bendable or foldable phones, it was Microsoft's HoloLens 2 that was the highlight for me. Not that I think it's an awesome product, because it's essentially useless to me the way it is right now, but I think it's a step in the right direction. And the direction is what this column is about.

Touch interfaces are very natural, and easy for pretty much anyone to master, and it's why toddlers love their iPads (if they have them), and take to the devices like ducks to water. Being old enough to have owned devices that used everything from joysticks and trackballs to navigate through menus on mobile devices, I can tell you with certainty that the touch interface was most certainly a huge improvement. But now it's time for a change.

The idea of touching something to activate, or move it, or using pinch to zoom in and out, etc., is not the real problem at all, to be honest, but it's the hardware interface (the screen) that needs to go. Why? Because it's turned us into screen zombies. And also, it's very limiting in terms of what can be done. It's why curving the edge of a screen to not make the edges look so sharp feels like a significant leap forward. It's still essentially a rectangle, but manufacturers are at least trying to hide that fact from you...

For decades now, all we've essentially done is make our TVs smaller and smaller, and given them more and more power and versatility to be able to show us a lot of different stuff. We went from scheduled programming of TV shows to PCs and laptops that gave you the internet and gaming, and then to phones, which made it all super portable and a lot more private. And yes, that privacy is the real reason phones overtook

everything else tech, and now rule our lives. TVs were made for groups of people, and were a family affair. PCs started off as learning and entertainment tools, which then evolved into laptops – even more “personal computers” than desktop PCs! And finally, tablets and mobiles overtook laptops, because they were even more portable and personal than 13-inch to 17-inch laptop screens.

Augmented reality is poised to rule the roost, but it still has a long, long way to go. Even the HoloLens 2 is miles away from a consumer product that can replace our phones. Don't be fooled by the demos, AR devices are nowhere close to ready. In fact, the videos that are shown off to the public are nowhere close to the real experience. For example, most people think that what we see in videos of the HoloLens 2 is actually what the wearer is seeing. It's not. The wearer essentially sees a box, in which holograms are created by the software. Get too close to the object being displayed, and it will get cut off at the edges the exact same way it would if you were shooting a video of it and got too close.

That said, there is no other interface that is poised to replace physical screens, so my hopes are pinned on AR. It took Microsoft 4 years to go from a 34-degree field of view (fov) in the original HoloLens, to now a 52-degree diagonal fov. Of course, they had to work on a million other things as well, such as making sure it was lighter and more balanced, and eye tracked better, and other stuff, but it is a big deal to improve fov dramatically. For comparison, consider that we humans have about 210-degree horizontal fov and 150-degree vertical fov. That should give you an indicator of how far the tech still has to go. It will get there though because holographs are even more private than smartphones, and once the tech matures, it will give us far better visual quality and experience than a silly phone. Most importantly, it will encourage us to look up, to pay attention to the world, and to notice reality more. Of course, we will still be busy getting all our dopamine fixes, but at least we might start noticing one another again as well... 



“The idea of touching something to activate, or move it, or using pinch to zoom in and out, etc., is not the real problem at all, to be honest, but it's the hardware interface (the screen) that needs to go.”



Liked or hated this column? Let me know at: editor@digit.in
| facebook.com/raaabo
| [@raaabo](https://twitter.com/raaabo)